

DEONTOLOGICAL ETHICS

KANT, ROSS & SCANLON

Introduction to Deontological Ethics:

Moral theory attempts to provide a systematic account of morality as a normative system.

Normative ethics is concerned with standards for right conduct and moral evaluation.

Deontological theories define **the right independently of the good**.
This contrasts with teleological theories, which define the good first and then the right as what promotes that good (e.g., Utilitarianism).

Deontology focuses on **duty** and **moral obligation** as central to determining the rightness of actions.

Features of Deontological Theories:

They focus on providing an account of **right actions**. Actions are judged based on their **adherence to rules or duties**, rather than their consequences.

The concepts of 'duty' and 'virtue' are paramount to the overall analysis within these theories.

Moral obligations are understood to be *prima facie* (unless overridden by countervailing considerations) and are not morally optional.They often posit a **categorical 'ought'**, meaning that reasons for action are good irrespective of an agent's desires.

Deontology :Immanuel Kant

Core Principle: A morally worthy action is one performed **in accordance with the Categorical Imperative**.

Categorical Imperative:It requires an agent to **refrain from acting in a way that fails to respect the rational nature of other persons**.This is often articulated as the "universal law" formulation: acting only on maxims that one could rationally will to be a universal law.

Respect for Persons: Persons are to be treated as **ends in themselves**, not merely as means to an end. This principle underlines why certain actions (e.g., false promises) are wrong.

Autonomy: The will, when guided by morality, is autonomous, meaning it gives the law to itself. This contrasts with heteronomy, where the will is driven by external factors like inclinations.

Moral Reasons: Kant argues that true moral judgments express **categorical imperatives** because they rely on reasons that are independent of the agent's preferences or empirical facts about human beings.

Deontology: W. D. Ross.

Core Principle: The right action is the action that **best accords with the fulfillment and/or non-violation of one's *prima facie* duties**.

Prima Facie Duties: These are duties that are obligatory "unless there is some countervailing consideration". Examples of such duties include telling the truth or keeping promises, which can be overridden in specific circumstances.

Pluralism: Ross's approach is **intuitionist and pluralist**, recognizing multiple, distinct ultimate moral principles (e.g., duties of fidelity, gratitude, justice, beneficence) rather than one single overarching principle like utility.

This approach aligns with earlier British moralists like Price and Reid.

Contractualism: T. M. Scanlon

Core Principle: An action is morally wrong if it is an act that **would be forbidden by principles that rational persons could not reasonably reject**.

Reasonable Rejection: The focus is on identifying moral principles that no rational person, motivated to find principles for general regulation of behavior, could reasonably reject.

This framework emphasizes a mutual recognition of what we **owe to each other** as rational beings

SUMMARY

Deontological ethics provides a robust framework for understanding morality based on **duty, rules, and intrinsic rightness**, independent of outcomes.

The major types, including Kantian, Rossian, and Contractualist approaches, offer distinct yet coherent perspectives on how moral agents should determine and fulfill their obligations.

This theory continues to be a fundamental and influential area of study in moral philosophy.

SOURCES:

- **Driver, J.** (2006). *Ethics: The Fundamentals*. Blackwell Publishing.

- **Driver, J.** (2022, June 27). Moral Theory. In *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*. Retrieved from Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy website.

- **Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy.** (n.d.). *Ethics*. Retrieved from Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy website.

- **Irwin, T.** (2020). *Ethics Through History: An Introduction*. Oxford University Press.